The Kingdom of Kongo

The Kingdom of Kongo was a kingdom situated in west-central Africa. Its territory encompassed the Atlantic Ocean, west of the Kwango River, all through to the Congo River and north to the Kwanza River. Kongo had several provinces ruled by the Manikongo, known as the king. However, its influence reached many neighboring kingdoms such as Matamba, Ndongo, Kakongo and others.

The kingdom of Kongo existed as an independent state from 1390 to 1891 and as a state of the kingdom of Portugal from 1891 to 1914. Kongo was officially founded by Lukeni Lua Nimi in 1390. Before that, small Iron Age communities settled north of the Congo River because of the fertile soil, iron and copper ores that were present near the river. As time passed, this small settlement prospered and grew wealthy. By the 15th century, many communities had developed into a small federation of loose towns. These towns then incorporated territories to eventually become a royal patrimony. The capital of Kongo was known as Mbanza Kongo and it became densely populated, allowing the king to keep his resources close at hand. Furthermore, the kingdom was able to create two principal harbors that became known as Pinda and Sonyo.

People from the Kongo mostly lived on agricultural production, fishing, and hunting. The governors were commanded to collect taxes, force labor upon some of the people and collect fines to continue growing. Due to abundance in natural resources, new crafts emerged relating to metalworking, pottery and raffia textiles. The ruling class mainly controlled these activities. The most prolific form of art was demonstrated in the nkisi objects, which were closely related to their religious beliefs. The nkisi figures were the only type of art made available to everyone.

The expansion of the Kongo territory was mainly accomplished through trading and forming alliances rather than through military conquests. The power of the Manikongo (the king) was exercised by some governors and there were three leading states in the kingdom: Loango, Ngoyo, and Kakongo. Expeditions were launched in search of new territory when there